

William Jackson and Ann Pearsall



A Family History

by Shelley Dawson Davies

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Chapter 1

WILLIAM AND ANN

Standing Fast

Ann Pearsall¹ was born at the high point of one of the most transformative eras in history. The Industrial Revolution, a period when the hand production of goods was replaced by a variety of water and steam-powered machines, altered almost every aspect of daily life. Families who had once subsisted on country farms were moving in great numbers to towns and cities where paying factory jobs and a higher standard of living could be had. Town dwellers like James² and Sarah Pearsall,³ who had made the St. Martin parish of Birmingham, Warwickshire, their home, were among those who participated in the swell of growth as workshops and small factories mushroomed across the town. Birmingham became known as known as the “city of a thousand trades” thanks to the wide variety of goods manufactured there, including buttons, cutlery, nails, guns, tools, jewelry, toys, locks and ornaments.

Ann, the second child of nine children,⁴ was christened a month after her birth on a cold November day in 1819.⁵ The Pearsall’s baptized all of their children at the church of St. Martin, the only remarkable building in the neighborhood of black and white half-timbered houses lining the crooked streets. St. Martin’s church stood at the center of the oldest and most populated of Birmingham’s districts, where food and agricultural markets had been held several times a week since medieval times, and the streets were still patrolled at night by lantern-bearing watchmen.

Like every other young girl in England, Ann was raised with strict moral values and a deep belief in God. The Bible was not only the text at church services, which some families attended twice every Sunday, but provided the stories and allegories used at home to instill correct behavior. Ann and her sisters were taught to cook, sew and care for their home with the expectation that one day they were assume the most important role of their lives, that of wife and mother. Ann assumed that role in October, 1838,⁶ when she married twenty-four year old Joseph Avery,⁷ a Birmingham glass cutter.⁸

Joseph and Ann were delighted by the birth of a son in February, 1840,⁹ naming him after Ann's father, James.¹⁰ Unfortunately, Grandfather Pearsall died suddenly the next year,¹¹ leaving Sarah a widow at the age of forty-six. Joseph and Ann moved into the Pearsall home to help support Sarah and Ann's teenaged sister Maria,¹² who helped care for little James while the three women worked to earn money making mother-of-pearl buttons.¹³ Only ten months later, James died as well, on the first of November,¹⁴ followed by Joseph's death in the first weeks of 1842.¹⁵ Ann was only twenty-three years old.



Button blanks cut and ready to process by hand.

The Birmingham Button Trade

Birmingham buttons had an international reputation in the mid-nineteenth century when an estimated seventeen-thousand workers crafted buttons from metal, jet, ivory, tortoiseshell, bone, horn, and glass. Some of the most popular fasteners were mother of pearl buttons made from imported shells so fragile they had to carefully worked by hand in small workshops, often found on the ground floor of squalid “back-to-back” slum dwellings. Up to eighty separate processes were required to manufacture the best buttons, from determining the best cuts from the shells, stamping, pressing and drilling holes in the blanks, to polishing, sorting sizes and sewing the buttons to cards ready for sale. Although some tasks required highly skilled hands, many of the jobs could be done by children as young as eight years, who could process up to a thousand buttons a day.

Ann remarried right away in April, 1842.¹⁶ William Jackson,¹⁷ also a native of Birmingham, was five years her senior and able to provide a stable home in the small town of Stone, thirty-seven miles to the north. Nestled in the pastoral valley of the River Trent, the village was a pleasant change from industrial Birmingham. Stone had been a market town for hundreds of years, and boasted “may well-stocked shops and good houses.” It was also an important stop on the stagecoach route, with as many as thirty-eight coaches passing through the town daily, making it a “very lively town.”¹⁸

With the comfort of once again having a home and husband to care for, Ann looked forward to becoming a mother. She gave birth to five daughters over the next ten years,¹⁹ beginning with Emily²⁰ in the spring of 1844. Two years later Maria²¹ was born in November, but lived only two short months. Little Sarah Ann²² followed in March, 1850, and grew to be healthy toddler, but Mary Ann,²³ born in January, 1852, died at the age of eighteen months, five months before Ann gave birth to her last child, Ellen,²⁴ in November, 1854.²⁵



A road approaching the village of Stone, Staffordshire.

The Gospel Light

Only a few months after Ann was born, an event that would change the world even more than the Industrial Revolution took place in a remote village in upstate New York. In the early spring of 1820, young Joseph Smith received a vision initiating the restoration of the Lord's own church. By 1837, the growing church had received instructions from the Lord to spread the good news of the gospel's restoration in England. Missionaries from the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints travelled across the country, preaching wherever they could.

Despite rejection and persecution, the Elders found many people willing to listen to their message and the church grew rapidly, especially in the Northwest and Midlands areas. By the time the missionaries baptized William and Ann in 1849,²⁶ there were eighteen-thousand Latter-day Saints in England. Two years later there were more members in the United Kingdom and Ireland than there were in Utah,²⁷ but unfortunately, William and Ann's family members were not among them.²⁸

William and Ann dedicated themselves to the gospel, making sure all of their girls were baptized as they came of age. They shrugged off the teasing of friends, hosted the Elders, and attended Sunday meetings where the sermons were full of encouragement for the Saints to join the main body of the church in Salt Lake City. The Jacksons were determined to be among the thousands of members who were courageous enough to leave their homes for a new life in the desert, and they began to set aside a few coins for passage whenever they could. They saved and planned for eight years, until William was debilitated by an unidentified "disease of the brain." He suffered for six weeks before dying on an icy day in January, 1858,²⁹ leaving Ann a widow for the second time at the age of thirty-nine.

Both of Ann's parents had died years before, and while she still had brothers and sisters living in the area, they continued to distance themselves from the church. As difficult as it would be for her to leave what remaining family she had, Ann recommitted herself to somehow making the journey to Zion. There were few options for single mothers to earn a living in a time when women were generally supported by either a husband or father. Ann, who was unable to either read or write,³⁰ may have struggled to feed and clothe the girls by falling back on her button making skills, or taking in sewing or laundry, or by working in a shop. It took her seven years of working and saving, but finally, in 1865, she was ready to embark on the journey to America.

Sailing Away

With the help of the local church leadership Ann booked passage on the *Bell Wood*, where she and her daughters were among the six hundred LDS immigrants departing Liverpool on Saturday, 19 April, 1865.³¹ The immigrants were a mixed group of converts from across Europe. “Most of them couldn’t speak a word of English, yet they all had one thing in common, the gospel, and one common destination, Utah,” wrote fellow immigrant Agnes Herffern.³²

The *Bell Wood* was not a new or a comfortable ship. Soon after the tug had pulled her out far enough to set sail, the ship began to leak. “We had to pump her three times a day,” wrote passenger Robert Pixton³³ With passenger accommodations located below deck, Ann and the girls were forced to carefully find their way to the rough bunks with light from large coal oil lamps swinging from chains. Food was prepared on large stoves by rotating assignments among ward members. In good weather, everyone ate in the fresh air on deck, but were forced to take their dinner at their bedsides during storms. Rough weather made eating difficult as the ship tossed around both people and food. During one storm, Agnes Hefferan recalled that “everything on the stove was pitched off onto the floor. Everyone had to wait until the things were cleaned up and more dinner prepared before they could eat.”³⁴

Time was passed onboard week after week with cooking and cleaning chores, short walks on deck and morning and evening prayer meetings where testimonies were shared. A special social committee was organized to plan events “at which well-selected pieces were recited” and a small brass band, “assisted by one or two good violinists, also by a flute and clarinet, made sweet melody to beguile the leisure hours of our trip, and filled the air with pleasant strains of music.”³⁵ Land was finally sighted near the end of May, five weeks after the *Belle Wood’s* departure. The ship was towed to a dock at New York’s Castle Garden where passengers were examined and cleared for entry into the United States.

The immigrants entered a country that was adjusting to the end of the Civil War and President Lincoln’s assassination, both of which had taken place only two months earlier. The Jacksons found themselves among the newcomers walking New York’s streets, eyes wide with interest at the number of returning troops. “Everywhere we saw soldiers who were returning home from the Civil War,” recalled fellow immigrant Mary Ann Mace. “I remember one troop carrying what remained of a huge American flag. The center had been taken out by a cannon ball, and soldiers were carrying it down the street by its corners. They looked ragged, tired and sick as they dragged themselves down the street to their quarters amid the sound of cheers and martial music.”³⁶

As fascinating as the city was, the immigrants were more concerned with the next half of their journey. Those who had means were booked onward by rail to the staging town of Wyoming, Nebraska, where arrangements for oxen and wagons were under way. The six hundred immigrants camped near town for two long months, huddled in canvas tents “muddy and disagreeable” during “fearfully grand” thunder storms, waiting for a place in wagon trains headed west.³⁷ Due to a shortage of funds and the inflated prices of goods, many of the Saints were unable to continue to Utah that season, including Ann and her daughters, who found accommodations and work seven miles south in Nebraska City.



Looking toward Cedar City, Utah.

Life in Zion

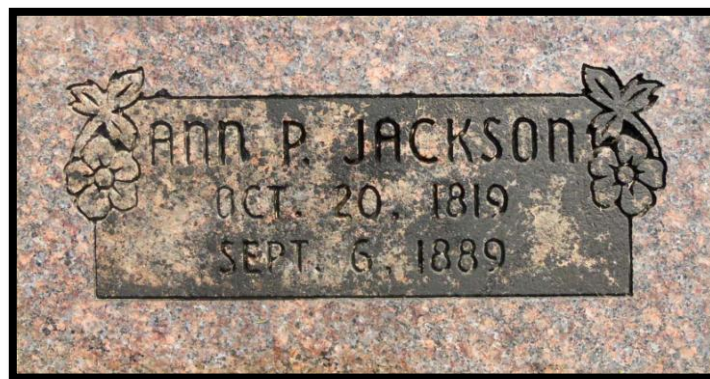
The Jacksons would remain in Nebraska City for eight years before they were able to complete their journey to Zion. In the meantime, all three of the girls married and began families of their own. Emily and Sarah both wed fellow English converts in the spring and fall of 1868; Ellen married four years later in 1872. At some point Ann joined Emily and her growing family to help care for the children as they arrived,³⁸ and eventually made the trip to Salt Lake with them by rail in 1873.³⁹ Emily and Joseph Hicks⁴⁰ moved to Sanpete County, where they settled their children in the town of Fountain Green. Sarah and John Storer⁴¹ came the next year, choosing to live a small farming

community in Summit County, while Ellen and Christopher Weaver⁴² found a similar town north of Salt Lake City in Davis County.

For some reason Ann decided not to live with any of her children, making her way instead to Cedar City in southern Utah. She was fifty-four years old by then, suffering from asthma⁴³ and completely separated from her family for the first time in her life. Soon after she arrived in Cedar City she sought the comfort of a patriarchal blessing, which promised that her “numerous posterity shall perpetuate thy name and that of thy departed companion to all generations,” and “no good thing shall be withheld from thee.”⁴⁴ Ann continued to find great solace in the gospel for which she had sacrificed so much, and remained faithful in her heart to her husband, William, to whom she was sealed in the St. George temple several years later.⁴⁵

Although she had arrived in Utah during the period when many women entered into polygamous marriages, Ann remained single in spirit and in fact. She never married again, supporting herself instead by taking a position as a servant in the large polygamous family of Henry Lunt.⁴⁶ Henry was an important man in Cedar City. As the town’s founder, he held civic and church leadership positions for over thirty years. His household of four wives and thirteen children was a challenge to manage, especially for Ann. Struggling with the workload of four families only aggravated Ann’s asthma, sapping what remained of her health and energy. Her episodes of wheezing, coughing and shortness of breath became more frequent until she was finally forced to leave the Lunts’ employ and move in with her daughter Ellen Weaver and husband Christopher, who had by then established a home in Kaysville.

The Weavers did their best to care for Ann on their large farm, but her health gradually failed. She passed away at the age of sixty-two on 7 September, 1881,⁴⁷ surrounded by four of her many grandchildren.⁴⁸ Ellen buried her mother in the Weaver family plot in the Kaysville cemetery, where she lies under the shadow of the Wasatch Mountains.⁴⁹



ENDNOTES

¹ Ann (Pearsall) Avery Jackson (1819-1891), #KWJF-SZM, www.new.familysearch.org.

² James Pearsall (1791-1841).

³ Sarah (Cadman) Pearsall (1795-1844).

⁴ William Pearsall (1817-); George Pearsall (1821-); Maria (Pearsall) Avery (1823-1859); Emma Pearsall (1825-); Sarah Pearsall (1825-); Eliza Pearsall (1829-); James Pearsall (1831-); Harriet (Pearsall) Ingram (1833-). Most of the vital information on Ann and her family has been obtained from www.new.familysearch.org. It has not been possible to independently verify this information as of July, 2013.

⁵ Ann was born 20 October and was christened 15 November, 1819.

www.new.familysearch.org.

⁶ *Ibid.*

⁷ Joseph Avery (1814-1842), #KLGJ-15G, www.new.familysearch.org.

⁸ Sarah Pearsall household, 1841 England census, Class: HO107; Piece: 1147; Book: 8; Civil Parish: St Thomas; County: Warwickshire; Enumeration District: 24; Folio: 45; Page: 11; Line: 13; GSU roll: 464182.

⁹ England and Wales Free BMD Birth Index, Jan-Feb-Mar 1840, Birmingham, Warwickshire, vol. 16, page 370. www.ancestry.com.

¹⁰ James Avery (1840-1841).

¹¹ James died 8 January, 1841.

¹² Maria (Pearsall) Avery (1823-1859).

¹³ Sarah Pearsall household, 1841 England census, Class: HO107; Piece: 1147; Book: 8; Civil Parish: St Thomas; County: Warwickshire; Enumeration District: 24; Folio: 45; Page: 11; Line: 13; GSU roll: 464182.

¹⁴ England and Wales Free BMD Death Index, 1837-1915, Oct-Nov-Dec 1841, Birmingham, Warwickshire, vol. 16, page 260. www.ancestry.com.

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, page 292.

¹⁶ Ann's sister Maria married Joseph's brother Robert Avery (1823-1852) on 27 March, 1842, several weeks before Ann's second marriage to William Jackson. See www.new.familysearch.org.

¹⁷ William Jackson (1815-1858), #KWJF-SZ9, www.new.familysearch.org.

¹⁸ History, Gazetteer and Directory of Staffordshire (William White, Sheffield, 1851). <http://www.genuki.org.uk/big/eng/STS/Stone/>

¹⁹ William Jackson-Ann Pearsall family group sheet, supplied 1977 by Max Weaver. This sheet offers only a generic list of materials consulted.

²⁰ Emily (Jackson) Hicks (1844-1902).

²¹ Maria Jackson (1846-1847).

²² Sarah Ann (Jackson) Storer Davies (1849-1930).

²³ Mary Ann Jackson (1852-1854).

²⁴ Ellen (Jackson) Weaver (1854-1931).

²⁵ Ellen Jackson, certified copy of an entry of birth, 7 November, 1854, 459 Summer Street, Stourbridge, Worcestershire and Staffordshire, given at the General Register Office, London; application 8018H, 1 February, 1979. Copy held by Shelley Dawson Davies.

²⁶ William Jackson-Ann Pearsall family group sheet, supplied 1977 by Max Weaver.

²⁷ Membership in Utah was 12,000, while there were 24, 199 Saints in the United Kingdom and Ireland by 1851. See <http://www.lightplanet.com/mormons/daily/history/british.html>.

²⁸ Ann's patriarchal blessing referred to relatives who "have rejected thy testimony," promising they would "redeemed when they have paid the debt of their rebellion." Ann Pearsall Jackson, "Patriarchal Blessing," given 23 November, 1874, Cedar City, Utah. Copy held by Shelley Dawson Davies.

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- ²⁹ William Jackson, certified copy on an entry of death, 22 January, 1858, Beauty Bank, Stourbridge, Worcestershire and Staffordshire, given at the General Register Office, London; application 5189H, 18 January, 1980. Copy held by Shelley Dawson Davies.
- ³⁰ Henry Lunt household, 1880 U. S. census, Iron County, Utah Territory, population schedule, town of Cedar City, Enumeration district 022, page 369C, Roll 1336, FHL #1255336.
- ³¹ See passenger list at
http://mormonmigration.lib.byu.edu/Search/showDetails/db:MM_MII/t:voyage/id:58/keyword:s:ann+jackson
- ³² Agnes C. Hefferan Richardson, "Reminiscences,"
http://mormonmigration.lib.byu.edu/Search/showDetails/db:MM_MII/t:account/id:143/keywords:ann+jackson
- ³³ Robert Pixton, "Autobiography,"
http://mormonmigration.lib.byu.edu/Search/showDetails/db:MM_MII/t:account/id:142/keywords:ann+jackson
- ³⁴ Richardson, "Reminiscences."
- ³⁵ William H. Shearman, "Letter from the Belle Wood, 30 May, 1865," published in *The Latter-day Saint Millennial Star*, 24 June, 1865.
http://mormonmigration.lib.byu.edu/Search/showDetails/db:MM_MII/t:account/id:144/keywords:ann+jackson
- ³⁶ Mary Ann Greenhlagh Mace, "Autobiography,"
http://mormonmigration.lib.byu.edu/Search/showDetails/db:MM_MII/t:account/id:140/keywords:ann+jackson
- ³⁷ Shearman, "Letter from the Belle Wood, 30 May, 1865."
- ³⁸ Joseph Hicks household, 1870 U. S. census, Otoe County, Nebraska, population schedule, town of Nebraska City, Roll: M593_831; Page: 386B; Image: 286; Family History Library Film: 552330. www.ancestry.com.
- ³⁹ No records were kept on immigrant arrivals after rail travel made wagon trains obsolete. It can be assumed Ann and the Hicks family made the trip in 1873, as Ann was endowed in Salt Lake City and Emily gave birth in Fountain Green, Utah that year. See www.new.familysearch.org.
- ⁴⁰ Joseph Hicks (1809-1899).
- ⁴¹ John George Storer (1850-1898).
- ⁴² Christopher Weaver (1842-1926).
- ⁴³ Henry Lunt household, 1880 U. S. census, Iron County, Utah Territory, population schedule, town of Cedar City, Enumeration district 022, page 369C, Roll 1336, FHL #1255336.
- ⁴⁴ Ann Pearsall Jackson, "Patriarchal Blessing," given 23 November, 1874, Cedar City, Utah.
- ⁴⁵ William and Ann were sealed 2 June, 1880.
- ⁴⁶ Henry Lunt household, 1880 U. S. census, Iron County, Utah Territory, population schedule, town of Cedar City, Enumeration district 022, page 369C, Roll 1336, FHL #1255336.
- ⁴⁷ Utah Cemetery Inventory, Utah State Historical Society, www.ancestry.com.
- ⁴⁸ Ann was grandmother to twenty-seven grandchildren, fifteen of whom survived to adulthood.
- ⁴⁹ Grave 15-3-A-9, Utah Cemetery Inventory, Utah State Historical Society, www.ancestry.com.

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Warwickshire, Birmingham. 1841 England census.

Class: HO107; Piece: 1147; Book: 8; GSU roll: 464182. www.ancestry.com.

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